



MoUs SIGNED

- Planning Commission and National Development and Reform Commission of China
- Ministry of Railways, India & Ministry of Railways, China
- Ministry of Housing & Urban Poverty Alleviation, India and Ministry of Construction, China
- Ministry of Rural Development and Chinese Ministry of Land Resources
- ICCR and Chinese People's Association for Friendship with Foreign Countries on medical mission, and one more on culture
- GSI and the Chinese Geological Survey
- Ministry of Health and the State Administration of Traditional Chinese Medicine
- Nabard and Agricultural Development Bank of China
- Ministry of Agriculture and Chinese General Administration of Quality Supervision Inspection and Quarantine for export of tobacco leaves



PRABHU CHAWLA

THE M-TEAM: Narayanan, Rao, Nair and Menon (above); Manmohan at a CII business session (top)

Buoyed by the surge, the two countries now intend to take it to \$60 billion (Rs 2.4 lakh crore) two years from now. Last year, the balance of trade was \$8 billion (Rs 32,000 crore) in favour of the Chinese, which explains why the smiles are missing from the faces of Indian businessmen. But Manmohan recalled that when he began the process of unshackling the Indian economy in 1991, the so called "Bombay Club" which then included several of today's industry titans was full of fierce protectionists who had opposed his initiatives fearing Indian companies could be swamped by competition from overseas. Fifteen years down the line, the fact that Indian companies are not just competing and beating but even gobbling up some of the competition is proof that the good doctor had got his prescription right back then.

MISSING OUT ON THE ACTION: Considering that one of the dozen MoUs signed during the visit was between the Planning Commission and the National Development and Reforms Commission of China, it seemed rather odd that Montek Singh Ahluwalia, the chief of our Plan panel, who is as ubiquitous as the commander on every prime ministerial flight, did not accompany his long-time boss. His absence was noted most by the pack of travelling hacks who missed Ahluwalia's jargons. Commerce Minister Kamal Nath signed the document on behalf of the Planning Commission.

MALLU MONOPOLY: Never have the three wings of the civil services worked in such perfect unison. The four speeches that Manmohan made during his Beijing sojourn were similar in thought and tenor—cautious, accommodating and invariably open ended. Every time the prime minister read out his pre-

pared texts, the audience was all ears. All excepting three people who were simultaneously poring over copies of the speech, to which only they were privy. They were the Principal Secretary T.K.A. Nair, IAS, Foreign Secretary Shiv Shankar menon, IFS, and National Security Advisor M.K. Narayanan, IFS. The three Keralites were of course joined in Beijing by Nirupama Rao, our ambassador, who too is originally from Kerala. Did someone say Mallu mafia?

MODEL MEDIA: For Indian journalists used to browbeating politicians, the joint press conference addressed by Manmohan and Wen was nothing short of a revelation. Both the leaders used interpreters to convey their messages. Statements over, end of press conference. When you look at the chaos at some of the press conferences back home, the Chinese model doesn't look all that bad. ■